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Canada and the Sikh Diaspora in the Late 1970s

TOWARDS THE end of November 1975, I was told by my bosses that I should be ready to move from Gangtok to New Delhi by end February 1976 and start preparing for a posting as first secretary in the high commission of India in Ottawa, Canada. In the normal course, after the completion of various formalities, I should have reached Ottawa by early June 1976. But my predecessor Shamsher Singh (IPS 1957 Rajasthan) had other plans. He wanted to prolong his stay at Ottawa and had secured some minor assignment in the Montreal Summer Olympics (17 July to 1 August 1976). So I had to cool my heels in New Delhi till after he had finished with the Olympics. While I was waiting to depart for Ottawa in order to take charge from Shamsher over there, he suddenly landed in New Delhi.

Within a week or so of his arrival Shamsher Singh submitted his resignation from the service, foregoing the pension to which he would have been entitled had he put in one more year of service to complete the minimum qualifying service of twenty years. Within a few days of resigning he returned to Canada. Everybody was surprised as to which passport he had used for his return to Ottawa as he had already surrendered his diplomatic passport. Inquiries made by the MEA revealed that he had returned to Ottawa on an ordinary passport issued by the high commission of India at Ottawa, which he had obtained some months before his transfer, with the approval of High Commissioner Uma Shankar Bajpai (elder brother